The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

Iran accused **America** of violating the countries' ceasefire, and promised retaliation, after the American navy fired on an Iranian-flagged cargo ship in the Arabian Sea. America said the vessel was trying to evade its blockade. Donald Trump claimed that American forces had "blown a hole in the engine room" and then boarded the *Touska*. Iran called that an "act of armed piracy".

Iran's foreign ministry said the regime has "no plans" to attend **peace talks**. It said America's blockade was a sign of bad faith. Earlier Mr Trump said that American negotiators would return to Pakistan on Monday for further talks with Iranian officials. He again threatened to destroy Iran's power stations and bridges if no deal was reached. The ceasefire is due to end on Wednesday.

Sir Keir Starmer told parliament that he did not know Peter Mandelson had failed vetting for his appointment as ambassador to America. The British prime minister has faced calls to resign by opposition MPs, who accuse him of misleading the house when he claimed due process had been followed. Earlier a Downing Street spokesperson said he had "inadvertently misled" parliament.

American stocks fell slightly after markets opened in response to renewed tensions. The benchmark S&P 500 fell by around 0.1%; the

tech-heavy NASDAQ fell by 0.2% while the Dow Jones Industrial Average was largely unchanged. In Europe, the STOXX 600 declined by more than 0.7%. Oil prices climbed to around $94 a barrel, up 5% from last close.

USA **Rare Earth**, a mining company, agreed to acquire **Serra Verde Group**, a Brazilian miner, in a cash-and-stock deal worth about $2.8bn. Serra Verde runs one of the few heavy rare-earth mines outside China. It follows other industry tie-ups as America seeks to reduce its reliance on China, which produces more than 90% of global refined rare-earth materials.

Japan downgraded its **tsunami warning**, calling off evacuation orders it had issued after a 7.5 magnitude earthquake struck off the coast. Authorities initially warned that three-metre high waves were headed to Iwate and Aomori prefectures and urged residents to leave several coastal towns. No injuries were reported from the initial quake. Japan's meteorological agency warned that bigger waves could hit after the first.

Eli Lilly said it will buy Kelonia Therapeutics, which makes technology for treating blood-cancer, in a deal that could be worth as much as $7bn. It is the latest of several deals struck by the American drugmaker as it tries to expand business lines beyond its weight-loss drugs. The firm recently bought Orna Therapeutics, which makes similar treatments.

Figure of the day: $100bn, OpenAI's ad revenue goal for ChatGPT by 2030. Read about how sponsored chats are changing digital advertising.

Photograph: Reuters

Britain’s prime minister in trouble

Sir Keir Starmer’s premiership has entered another moment of peril. On Thursday the government confirmed that Peter Mandelson had failed security vetting before he was appointed Britain’s ambassador to America, a position from which he was later sacked because of his friendship with Jeffrey Epstein, a convicted (and deceased) sex offender. Sir Keir, who had previously insisted that “full due process” had been followed, said ministers were unaware of the failure. He promptly dismissed the Foreign Office’s top mandarin.

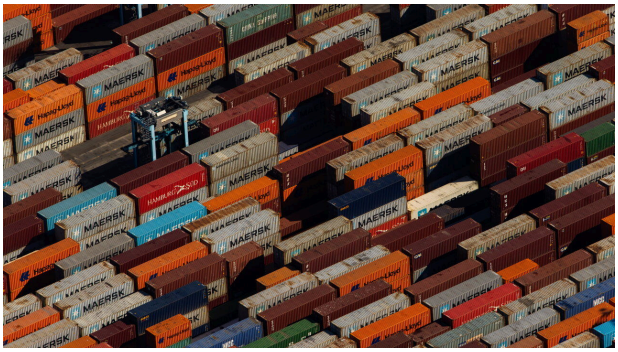
The prime minister rejects the opposition Conservative Party’s accusation that he lied. On Monday he will set out the “relevant facts in true transparency” in Parliament. Yet the idea that officials felt unwilling or unable to raise the vetting failure will only intensify concerns about Sir Keir’s leadership among Labour MPs. The party also faces the prospect of heavy losses in local elections on May 7th. Once those are over, if not before, the knives may be out.

Photograph: Getty Images

Ceasefires on the brink

The re-opening of the Strait of Hormuz lasted less than a day, as ships in the Gulf of Oman faced gunfire on Saturday; America and Iran pointed the blame at each other. The naval jockeying comes as Donald Trump sends American negotiators back to Islamabad, Pakistan's capital, for a second round of talks on Monday. (Iran has rejected the idea of new peace talks, according to state media.) Mr Trump's two-week ceasefire expires two days later. America's president has threatened to attack Iran's power plants and bridges if a deal isn't reached.

Meanwhile Mr Trump has been trying to enforce a second ceasefire between Israel and Hizbullah, Iran's proxy militia in Lebanon. On April 17th he imposed a ten-day truce on Israel. The next day he posted that Israel was "PROHIBITED" from bombing in Lebanon. Skirmishing has continued, with Israel carrying out drone strikes and two Israeli troops killed by Hizbullah's booby-traps. Here too, the clock is ticking and talks have yet to be scheduled.



Photograph: Getty Images

American buyers lose out twice

Losing a landmark Supreme Court case and seeing swathes of his tariff regime struck down was already embarrassing to Donald Trump. Adding insult to injury, importers are now also owed refunds on the duties unlawfully collected under the International Emergency Economic Powers Act. The bill comes to $166bn. (Some fiscal wonks have waspishly suggested that Mr Trump should try to push the refunds out as quickly as possible, as a sort of backdoor economic stimulus.)

On Monday the Trump administration will launch the electronic system that will process and distribute these refunds. Legally, these will be due to the entities that paid the tariffs to the government. Many of their customers will consider that unfair. The economic burden of the tariffs is often different from the legal one: importers push the extra costs onto purchasers. Now, buyers will suffer twice: first from the knock-on higher prices from tariffs, then by missing out on the refunds.

Photograph: Getty Images

Can America fight on two fronts?

American forces and their allies began 18 days of war games in the Philippines on Monday. The annual Exercise Balikatan (Filipino for “shoulder-to-shoulder”) is meant to tighten the network of alliances woven by America to stop China from seizing territory it claims in the western Pacific.

In the most extensive exercise yet, Australia, Canada, France, Japan, New Zealand and the Philippines are contributing to the total of 17,000 personnel who will practise war-fighting together on land, at sea, in the air and in cyberspace. They will anxiously note how many people, and what weaponry, America is sending, given its military entanglement in the Persian Gulf. A strong contingent would be reassuring. It would signal that, if necessary, America is capable of fighting two wars in separate theatres simultaneously. In the Pacific, America can fall back on its many allies. Unlike in the Gulf, where it relies largely on Israel.

Photograph: Getty Images

Happy 130th Boston Marathon!

More than 30,000 professional and amateur runners from 137 countries are expected to take part in the 130th Boston Marathon on Monday. The world's oldest marathon will be star-studded, including John Korir and Sharon Lokedi, who won last year's race. (Mr Korir also won marathons in Chicago in 2024 and Valencia in 2025.)

Just 15 men took part in Boston's inaugural race in 1897. Inspired by the first Olympic marathon in Athens the year before, it has since grown to become one of the most important events of the running calendar. Sixty years ago, Bobbi Gibb became the first woman to run the race. It was the first marathon to include a women's division from 1972, as well as a wheelchair division three years later.

In recent years it has become increasingly difficult to qualify for the race as standards have risen. And the idea of voluntarily running 42.2 kilometres is appealing to growing numbers, with more amateurs attempting the feat.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: Which Danish explorer spent many years leading expeditions for the Russian navy in the 18th century?

If the time is not ripe, we have to ripen the time.

Dorothy Height